

Action Time

To avoid Bihar-like situations in the future, the state and the Central governments should come together to formulate and implement an effective flood control programme ("Bihar's Misery", September 15). The Government should also consider the solution provided by K.L. Rao, minister for power and irrigation in the Indira Gandhi cabinet. He had proposed interlinking of rivers as a solution to drought and flood. An eminent engineer himself, had his plan been implemented then, such problems wouldn't have arisen today. But it is politics which didn't let things materialise then and even now the conditions aren't conducive enough to let things be.

C. RAM MOHAN, *Vijayawada*

War Within

Contemptible acts of arson, vandalism and the holocaust of innocent people in Orissa's Kandhamal district, Karnataka and Madhya Pradesh are against Hindus' moral philosophy ("The Rogue Army", October 13). Fanaticism of some self-proclaimed protagonists like Vinay Katiyar, Praveen Togadia and his ilk from the Bajrang Dal, VHP and RSS should not become idiosyncrasies of Hindu youths. If there are authentications in support that the volunteers of the saffron outfits like Bajrang Dal are terrorists, then the Government should resolutely exercise its authority provided in the Constitution to contain these rogues.

INDU SHANKAR, *Varanasi*

Soft Target

The chorus of despair not only laments 'Impotent India's' will to check terrorism, but also the Government's inability to provide security and help to people who are struck with tragedy after tragedy—whether man-made or by the wrath of nature ("Politics of Terror", September 29). While those affected by the floods are suffering from starvation and an

onslaught of diseases, those killed or injured in the blasts are no better with the apathy of the authorities making matters worse for them. When will the situations improve for the common man? It is ironical that the political parties do nothing more than offering lip service during such tragic situations for gaining electoral advantage.

LT. GEN. RAVI SHARMA (RETD),
Gurgaon

CAPITAL SHAME



VIKRAM SHARMA

After every blast, it has become almost routine to issue sketches of a few suspects, "crack" a master-plan, make up "encounters" of the so-called "terror masterminds" followed by some arrests to cover up the case ("Indian Mujahideen", September 29). What we need is a concrete strategy to deal with terror menace and setting up of fast-track courts to tackle terrorism-related cases to ensure stringent punishment for such heinous crimes.

TAPAS CHAKRABORTY, *on e-mail*

Union Home Minister Shivraj Patil reminds us of Nero ("Dressed to Kill", September 29). Like the Roman emperor, who was busy playing his violin while Rome was burning, Patil was busy changing dresses after five serial blasts shook the Capital. He had no concern and consideration for those who were injured or killed in the blasts.

P. BABU, *Geddanapalli, Andhra Pradesh*

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Years Ago in India Today

NOVEMBER 16-30, 1978



Beginning of the End?

It has taken Mrs Gandhi exactly 598 days to stage a comeback from the political limbo into which she was flung in March last year. When Parliament throws open its high doors for the winter session, there will be an old familiar face in a new unfamiliar place as Indira Priyadarshini Gandhi, India's prime minister for 11 years and a quasi-dictator for two years, is sworn in as an ordinary MP from Chikmagalur—a sleepy old place 1,500 miles from Delhi—which she saw for the first time in her life on October 6, 1978, and which now looms large on the country's political map. Mrs Gandhi's victory has started political tongues wagging all over the country. Many are wondering whether Chikmagalur is Mrs Gandhi's first stop on the way to Delhi. The election results by themselves are inconclusive. Chikmagalur is not such a setback to the ruling party as it is made out to be, nor is it much of a triumph for her party that considers it to be a safe Congress (I) seat anyway and Mrs Gandhi had campaigned there for three weeks with the backing of a powerful state set-up.

—Jay Dubeshi

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